

Title

"JCat and More – Innovative Tools for Jewish Ancestral Discovery"

Abstract

Initiated by the International Association of Jewish Genealogical Societies (IAJGS) as a big, bold, and urgent project, Documentation of Jewish Records Worldwide (DoJR) is documenting Jewish records worldwide and building JCat, the most comprehensive catalog of historical documents of Jewish lives. Marlis Humphrey, CEO of L'Dor V'Dor Foundation (LDVDF), the parent non-profit organization for the DoJR project, will showcase tools and resources available to researchers now... JCat-Phase 1, JDays, NewsNosh, Taxonomy/Checklists, Essentials Guides, AI transcription models... and share what is in the development pipeline and what the future will bring.

1. ABOUT LDVDF/DOJR

- The Documentation of Jewish Records Worldwide ([DoJR](#)) project was conceived of and incubated within the International Association of Jewish Genealogical Societies ([IAJGS](#)).
- DoJR is now operated worldwide by the non-profit L'Dor V'Dor Foundation ([LDVDF](#)), incorporated in the U.S. with a newly incorporated subsidiary L'Dor V'Dor Foundation Canada ([LDVDF-Canada](#)).
- DoJR is building the world's most comprehensive catalog of historical documents of Jewish lives, JCat. JCat is a meta-catalog similar to WorldCat.
- DoJR estimates that 85% of the record collections useful to Jewish ancestral discovery are unknown to researchers. We are surveying country by country to identify and catalog them.

2. JCAT, & JCAT PHASE 1

- JCat is focused on discovery where records are known to be at-risk and/or where little is known about the availability of records held in that region.
- The most typical way a researcher searches the JCat catalog, is by town name. The search results list record collections that document lives in or from that town.
- [JCat Phase 1](#) is online and searchable for free.
- JCat Phase 1 holds more than 10,000 searchable entries and includes only two record types: Jewish Newspapers and Yizkor Books from 7 organizations. Check back often for new entries.
- View this video walkthrough on [how to search JCat](#).
- JCat will expand to include more than 350 different record types. This survey work is underway.

3. TAXONOMY CHECKLISTS – A USEFUL TOOL

- When building your research plan or hitting a brick wall as if all resources have been exhausted, review the two taxonomy checklists.
- [Record Type Checklist](#) – what types of records may exist for your research.
- [Custodial Entity Type Checklist](#) – where might these records be held.
- The taxonomy checklists will be updated as DoJR continues its survey work and encounters new record and repository types.

4. THE ROLE OF AI

- The DoJR AI Lab is in its 5th year of training models to read historical documents in handwritten script of all the languages of the Diaspora. We work with university scholars, academic researchers, international Jewish organizations, genealogists, and others in collaboration.
- The DoJR AI Lab's goal is to automate the collection assessment and collection cataloging where collections are already digitized – using computers to accelerate the survey and cataloging work otherwise done by manual researchers. It starts with being able to read the handwriting.
- We are giving back to the research community and have published or collaborated on the publication of [public AI models](#) in Russian and Yiddish with others to follow.
- AI Large Language Models (e.g. ChatGPT) are not trained/specialized for handwriting recognition. A different type of AI technology and platform specializes in handwriting recognition and especially historical documents in old scripts, such as Transkribus. [Transkribus](#) is a powerful AI tool for transcription but has a learning curve including selection or training of a good language and sometimes layout model.
- In spring of 2025, we will offer a workshop for researchers interested in learning how to use the Transkribus platform for handwritten Jewish records. To receive notification, [subscribe](#) to the LDVDF email list.

5. COUNTRY SURVEYS & RECORDS-AT-RISK APPROACH

- Sometimes we aggregate information about records collections by record type, as we did for the Jewish Newspapers and Yizkor Book titles that are in JCat Phase 1. At the same time, we are

doing regional and country-wide surveys for all the record collections with Jewish genealogical value in the care of various organizations as well as in the attics and trunks of individuals.

- We use a three-phase process: Records-at-Risk Survey – 1) High level, identifying and profiling custodial entities, prioritize the most vulnerable, scope the next level survey; 2) Custodial Entities Survey – facility-by-facility deep dive and individuals' collections; and 3) Partnerships to digitize and preserve the most vulnerable collections.
- E.g., [Victoria, Australia](#) has catalogued more than 5,000 records and plans to survey 160 organizations. They are attracting local community partners to the DoJR project as a regional Jewish Community History collaboration.
- Records-at-Risk include records unprotected by legislation, such as the archives of businesses, charities and individuals, and any records vulnerable to impending damage or destruction due to natural or man-made disaster or environmental conditions – not only the physical deterioration of the documents, but also documents scheduled for intentional destruction or vulnerable to an unstable government or to antisemitism.
- We are fundraising for a [Records-at-Risk Survey in Poland](#) under a grant agreement with the U.S. Commission for the Preservation of America's Heritage Abroad.

6. ESSENTIALS GUIDES

- We are developing and publishing a series of research guides "The Essentials of Jewish Genealogy Research – (*country-name*)" with permission of Gary Mokotoff and Dr. Sallyann Sack, who have donated the 50 country chapters in the Avotaynu Guide to Jewish Genealogy.
- As we update and augment those chapters and create new country chapters to cover the entire Diaspora, you can download the Essentials guides for free from the LDVDF website. Download the unedited draft for the [Essentials for Canada](#) currently being updated.

7. LDVDF MISSION

- The LDVDF Organization's mission has ancestral discovery at its core. Specifically, "advancing ancestral discovery for anyone with interest in Jewish family history and heritage."
- Ancestral discovery for the LDVDF is broader than just the DoJR project, including other forms of genealogical evidence as well as the macro historical context against the backdrop of Jewish heritage, culture, and tradition.
- We are providing additional tools that aid a fuller understanding of ancestral discovery.

8. NEWS NOSH

- Published every Sunday by founder and editor, Phil Goldfarb, the "[Weekly News Nosh](#)" contains 1-2 dozen news items about Jewish genealogy, history, and heritage. You can [subscribe](#) to receive News Nosh to your email inbox weekly.

9. JDAYS

- [JDays](#) is the first ever worldwide Jewish event calendar advertising events, webinars, podcasts, film showing, social meet-ups, etc. all about genealogy as well as more generally about Jewish history or heritage. Events are in-person, on-line, and hybrid. You can [subscribe](#) to receive JDays to your email inbox monthly.

10. LDVDF-CANADA

- The DoJR-Canada Advisory Council is finalizing its plan for a [pan-Canada DoJR survey](#) supported by the core of the Canadian Jewish Genealogical Societies' leadership in [British Columbia](#), [Montreal](#), [Ottawa](#), and [Toronto](#), and key Jewish Canadian library and archive experts.
- Canada is home to the 4th largest Jewish population with 10 generations of records since the first settlers in the 1760s.

11. MOVING FORWARD

- DoJR is a big, bold, and urgent project. It is a decades long project which will scale to accomplish its survey and cataloging work in tens, if not hundreds, of thousands of repositories with a systematic approach and the assistance of volunteers, archivists, researchers, and AI.
- There are five actions you can take to help accelerate the discovery of more record collections for your research and the growth of JCat for use by the larger community and access by future generations: 1) Use [JCat Phase 1](#) and provide [feedback](#) so we can improve the usability; 2) If you know of a record collection or repository we should include in JCat, leave us a note in [Something I Know](#); 3) [Volunteer](#). We will find a meaningful task that fits your interests and time available; 4) [Subscribe](#) to stay informed about new tools for researchers; and 5) This vital work to discover and reclaim Jewish documentary heritage is 100% funded by donations. Please [donate](#).

Speaker Bio and Contact

[Marlis Humphrey](#) is CEO and President of the L'Dor V'Dor Foundation (LDVDF) and LDVDF Canada. Humphrey is a professional genealogist. She serves as Past President of the International Association of Jewish Genealogical Societies (IAJGS) and Director of the National Genealogical Society (NGS). Humphrey is leading the charge in bringing AI and other technology innovations to rescuing our Jewish documentary heritage.